

Minor Wounds & Bruises

Minor wounds, bruises, and grazes are part of everyday life, and the remedies listed make effective home treatments. Witch hazel is a very good astringent for minor scrapes, bruises, and swellings, protecting and soothing the damaged area. Arnica can be used to relieve bruising, pain, and swelling, and it combines well with witch hazel. Wounds can be cleansed with aloe vera gel which, like comfrey, is an excellent wound healer. Comfrey ointment is helpful in clearing old scars. See also *Sprains & Fractures*, p. 312.

⚠ **General caution** Seek immediate medical attention for serious or deep wounds, bruising, or scrapes, especially if the pain has not considerably lessened after 24 hours.

Cleansing Wounds

Herb Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56)

Remedy Make a yarrow lotion, allow to cool, and use as a wash.

Herb Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Make a calendula lotion with 2 heaping tsp of herb to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water, or use the tincture neat or diluted in water. Apply either preparation to the wound.

Note Calendula tincture will sting strongly, but it has a greater antiseptic action.

Herb Aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60)

Remedy Cleanse the wound with the gel and cover with a dressing soaked in gel. Change frequently.

Herb Witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102)

Remedy Apply distilled witch hazel (available over the counter) to the affected area 2–3 times a day.

Healing Wounds

Herbs Comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138), aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60)

Remedy Apply comfrey ointment at the edges of the wound or, once a scab has formed, use a comfrey poultice. Use aloe vera gel to cleanse the wound (see left).

Caution Do not use comfrey on an open wound.

Bruises

Herbs Arnica (*Arnica montana*, p. 172), witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102)

Remedy Apply arnica ointment to bruises and swellings 2–3 times a day, or use distilled witch hazel, as above.

Caution Do not use arnica on broken skin.

Cold Sores, Chicken Pox, Shingles, & Warts

Herbal medicine can help all these viral infections that affect the skin.

Cold sores are caused by the herpes simplex virus, and usually occur when the body has an infection or has been exposed to sunshine or wind. Tiny blisters form, mainly around the nostrils and lips.

Shingles and chicken pox are the result of a similar virus, causing sores to form all over the body. Shingles are a sign that the nervous system is run down and open to infection, so herbs that support the nerves and the immune system as a whole are as important as ones that work topically.

Warts, caused by the papilloma virus, can be difficult to clear. With persistence, the remedies here are often effective.

⚠ **General cautions** Always consult a professional practitioner if you have, or suspect you have, shingles. Take professional advice if you notice a sudden change to a wart.

Cold Sores, Chicken Pox, & Shingles

Herbs Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92), St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106)

Remedies Take $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of tincture of either herb with water 2–3 times a day. Alternatively, take echinacea tablets or capsules, or make an infusion of St. John's wort and drink up to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) a day.

Herbs Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59), ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155), lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82)

Remedy (Internal) Eat 1–2 cloves of garlic and 1–2 slices (1 g) of fresh ginger a day.

Remedy (External) Apply either fresh ginger, half a clove of garlic, or lemon juice to unopened cold sores, shingles, or pockmarks up to 6 times a day.

Herb Lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113)

Remedy (Internal) Make an infusion and drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Remedy (External) Make a lotion by infusing $1\frac{1}{2}$ tbsp of fresh or 3 tsp of dried leaves in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water for 10 minutes. Strain and dab onto spots 3–5 times a day.

Warts

Herb Aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60)

Remedy Apply the gel directly to the wart 2–3 times a day for up to 3 months.

Herb Arborvitae (*Thuja occidentalis*, p. 276)

Remedy Apply neat tincture to the wart 1–2 times a day for up to 3 months.

Fungal Skin Infections, Including Athlete's Foot

Fungal skin infections are easily picked up through physical contact, and can be hard to clear. Athlete's foot is a fungus (tinea) that grows in the skin between and under the toes, causing it to split and peel away. This itchy, sore condition can be difficult to treat at home.

Self-help

Keep feet dry and clean and do not wear synthetic socks or tightly fitting shoes.

General Remedies

Herb Comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138)

Remedy Make a poultice and firmly apply to the affected area for 1–2 hours each day.

Caution Do not use comfrey on broken skin.

Herbs Tea tree (*Melaleuca alternifolia*, p. 112), clove (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Mix 5 drops of tea tree, clove, or thyme essential oil with 1 tsp of calendula ointment. Apply 1–2 times a day.

Caution Do not use thyme oil during pregnancy.

Herb Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

Remedy Rub on $\frac{1}{2}$ clove 2–3 times a day.

Athlete's Foot

Herbs Turmeric (*Curcuma longa*, p. 90), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Mix $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of turmeric powder with 3 tsp (15 ml) of calendula ointment. Rub in between and under the toes each day.